

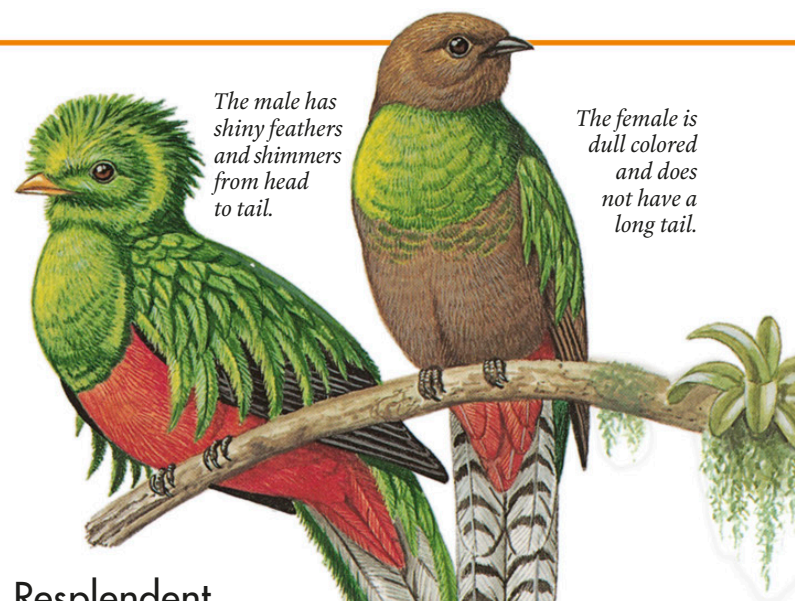
Central America and the Caribbean



THE RICH BIRD LIFE of Central America is partly due to the landscapes in the region, which vary from dry grassland on the west coast to alpine meadows in the middle and lush rainforest and swamps on the eastern coasts. Central America forms a narrow bridge linking North and South America, so birds from both continents mix there. Many North American birds

migrate to the warmer climate of Central America for the winter.

The Caribbean islands are the tips of mountains buried in very deep water. The birds here are either strong fliers that were able to reach the islands or they were blown there accidentally by strong winds. Several unique species have developed on the islands: the tody family, for example, is found nowhere else in the world.



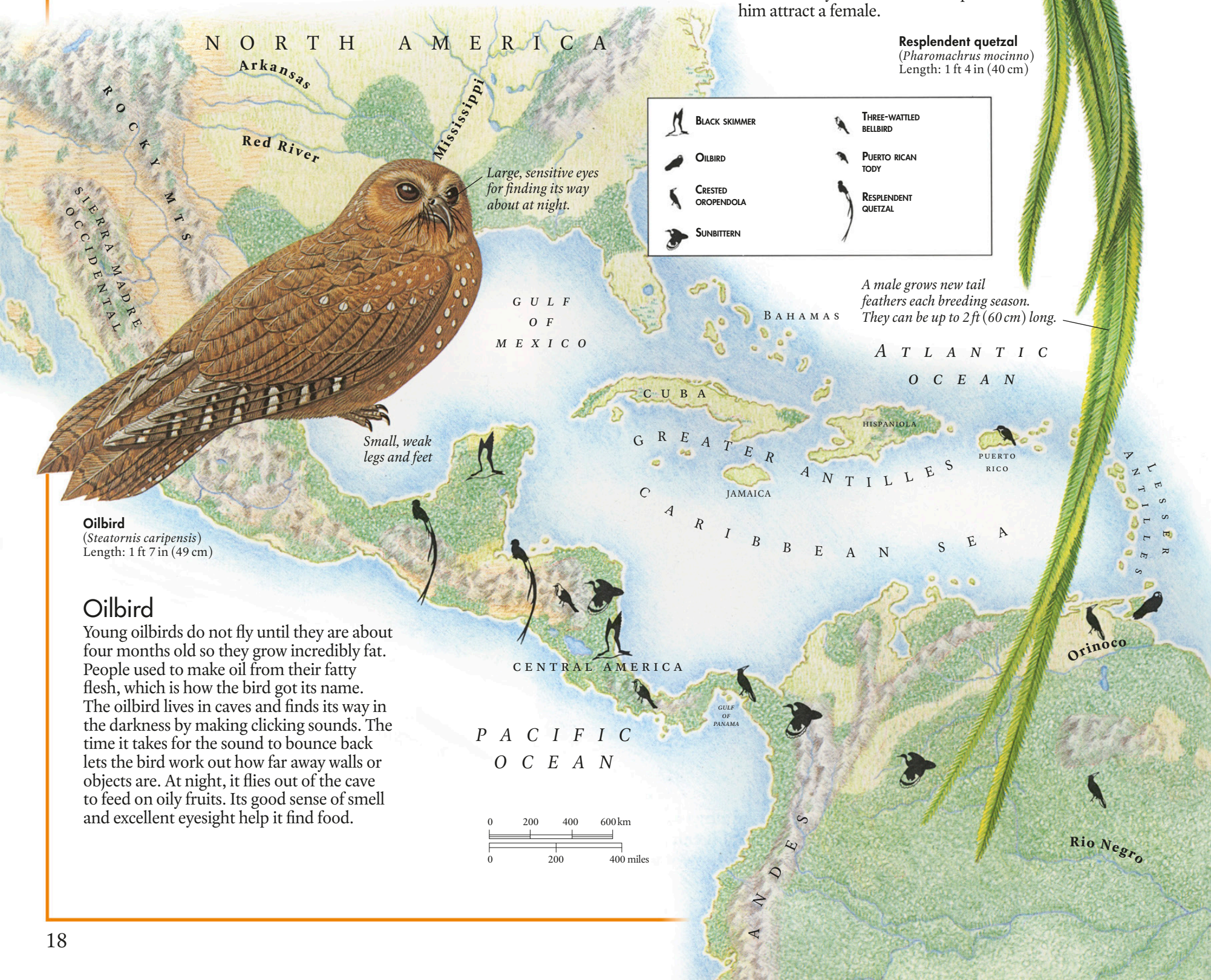
The male has shiny feathers and shimmers from head to tail.

The female is dull colored and does not have a long tail.

Resplendent quetzal

The ancient peoples of Central America, the Maya and the Aztecs, worshipped the quetzal as a sacred bird. Today it is the national bird of Guatemala. Quetzals usually live on their own, searching for fruit or insects in forest trees. The male has extraordinary tail feathers to help him attract a female.

Resplendent quetzal
(*Pharomachrus mocinno*)
Length: 1 ft 4 in (40 cm)



Oilbird
(*Steatornis caripensis*)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (49 cm)

Oilbird

Young oilbirds do not fly until they are about four months old so they grow incredibly fat. People used to make oil from their fatty flesh, which is how the bird got its name. The oilbird lives in caves and finds its way in the darkness by making clicking sounds. The time it takes for the sound to bounce back lets the bird work out how far away walls or objects are. At night, it flies out of the cave to feed on oily fruits. Its good sense of smell and excellent eyesight help it find food.